



Ashoka Philosophy Student Handbook
2024-2025 Version

Prepared by the Philosophy Student Representatives
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Why Philosophy?

If you study philosophy at Ashoka, you will explore the deepest, most pressing questions at the heart of intellectual inquiry. You will become familiar with the thoughts of renowned historical figures from across the world, like Socrates, Nagarjuna, Kongzi (Confucius), Nietzsche, Ambedkar, and dozens of others. You will also read cutting edge research by contemporary philosophers on topics like the ethics of artificial intelligence or the challenges posed by climate change.

Students who study philosophy learn to read, write, discuss, and think in a deep, searching, thoughtful manner. They become prepared to flourish in all kinds of careers, from consulting, journalism, law, business, and many others. An Ashoka philosophy education also puts students in an excellent position to pursue graduate studies in philosophy if they so choose.

Philosophy ranges over many disparate topics, like the philosophy of science, philosophy of mind, philosophy of language, ethics, political philosophy, logic, metaphysics, epistemology, and many others. Our department offers courses in these topics and many more, both from historical and contemporary perspectives.

The Philosophy faculty at Ashoka is world class and is dedicated to providing a compelling, challenging, and illuminating education to all of our students. There are many opportunities for independent studies, and students interested in independent research can write a thesis in their fourth year.

Requirements for a Degree in Philosophy

The department of Philosophy offers a 3-year major, a 4-year major, a 4-year major with research, a minor, a concentration, and interdisciplinary majors in Politics, Philosophy, and Economics (PPE); Philosophy and Computer Science (PHICS), and Psychology and Philosophy (PSYPHI).

For information about the requirements for these degrees please refer to the [department's website](#).

All Philosophy courses fall into one of five categories: **Required Courses**, **Contemporary Core**, **Indian and Non-Western Philosophy**, **History of Western Philosophy**, and **Elective Only**. You will be required to complete a combination of courses from these categories to complete any of the degree requirements. More information on course categories can be found [here](#).

Any Ashoka 4th year undergraduate student is eligible to write a thesis in Philosophy. A Capstone Thesis is a lengthy research paper (often 15 or more pages) on some topic in philosophy. It is an opportunity for students to learn how to conduct independent research in philosophy and to thoroughly explore a topic they are interested in. Information on how and when to register, as well as the requirements for Philosophy Capstone Thesis can be found on the [department's website](#).

Philosophy Society

The Ashoka Philosophy Society (PhilSoc) is an academic society that aims to make philosophy more accessible by illustrating how it is intrinsically linked not only to the liberal arts, but also to the process of thinking in general. It hosts a number of events over the academic year. It organises India's only undergraduate Philosophy conference, PhilCon. It is involved in the making of Citta, Ashoka's student-run, peer-reviewed undergraduate philosophy journal.

It can be reached at philsoc@ashoka.edu.in.

Philosophy Helpdesk

The Philosophy Helpdesk is a student initiative designed to provide help with critical thinking and academic writing in Philosophy. Tutors at the Helpdesk are 3rd year and 4th year Philosophy majors and minors who are available to peer-review your assignments and assist you with structuring your argument for a paper, feedback on a draft, concept clarification, homework sums, and more.

Appointments can be through Calendly using the links available on the Google Sheet sent out by philhelpdesk@ashoka.edu.in. The Philosophy Helpdesk is organised by the Student Representatives.

FAQs

Do I need to enrol in philosophy courses in a specific order?

You do not need to enrol in philosophy courses in a specific order. If a course has a prerequisite, this will be listed in the course catalogue. Most courses do not have prerequisites.

Can I write a thesis before my fourth year?

Yes; you can follow the thesis timeline by setting up an Independent Study Module (ISM) with a professor who agrees to advise your thesis.

Can I write a thesis if I am not a Philosophy major?

Yes; as long as you follow the requirements for a Philosophy Capstone Thesis, you may write a thesis, no matter what your major is. Note that unless you have majored in Philosophy, PPE, PSYPHI, or PHICS, it may be difficult to find a Philosophy professor to advise your thesis, because if you do not have a lot of experience in Philosophy courses you may not have the skills necessary to write a thesis.

Can any of the degree requirements be waived?

In exceptional circumstances it may be possible to waive certain degree requirements for Philosophy or any of the interdisciplinary majors. You can ask the Philosophy Head of Department and your academic advisor for more information.

My question is not listed here. Who should I ask?

If you have additional questions you can contact the Philosophy Student Representatives or any Philosophy professor.